

NATO

A Brief Introduction for INVISIO employees

NATO – the North Atlantic Treaty Organization – is a political and military alliance of **32 countries** in Europe and North America.

Its core purpose is to safeguard the freedom and security of its members through political cooperation, deterrence and collective defence.

01 — NATO at a glance

A brief history

1949 — NATO is founded

On 4 April 1949, 12 countries sign the North Atlantic Treaty in Washington, D.C. NATO is founded on shared values including democracy, individual liberty and the rule of law.

1989 — The Cold War ends

The fall of the Berlin Wall marks a turning point. NATO begins developing new forms of cooperation with former adversaries.

1995 — First major crisis operation

NATO conducts its first major crisis-management operation in Bosnia and Herzegovina.

2001 — Article 5 is invoked

Following the terrorist attacks against the United States on 11 September, NATO invokes Article 5 for the first time.

2003 — Afghanistan

NATO assumes command of the International Security Assistance Force (ISAF) in Afghanistan.

2014 — Crimea

Russia's illegal annexation of Crimea leads NATO to strengthen its eastern flank and increase its support for Ukraine.

2022 — A new Strategic Concept

Following Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine, NATO adopts a new Strategic Concept outlining the Alliance's strategic direction and priorities.

02 — The North Atlantic Treaty

Articles 1–5

The North Atlantic Treaty consists of 14 articles that establish the framework for NATO cooperation and collective defence.

ARTICLE 1

Peaceful conflict resolution

Members commit to resolving international disputes by peaceful means and to refrain from the threat or use of force inconsistent with the principles of the United Nations.

ARTICLE 2

Cooperation & stability

Members work to strengthen democratic institutions, promote stability and develop economic and political cooperation.

ARTICLE 3

Building defence capabilities

Members maintain and develop their individual and collective capacity to resist armed attack.

ARTICLE 4

Consultation

Members consult whenever the territorial integrity, political independence or security of any member is threatened.

ARTICLE 5

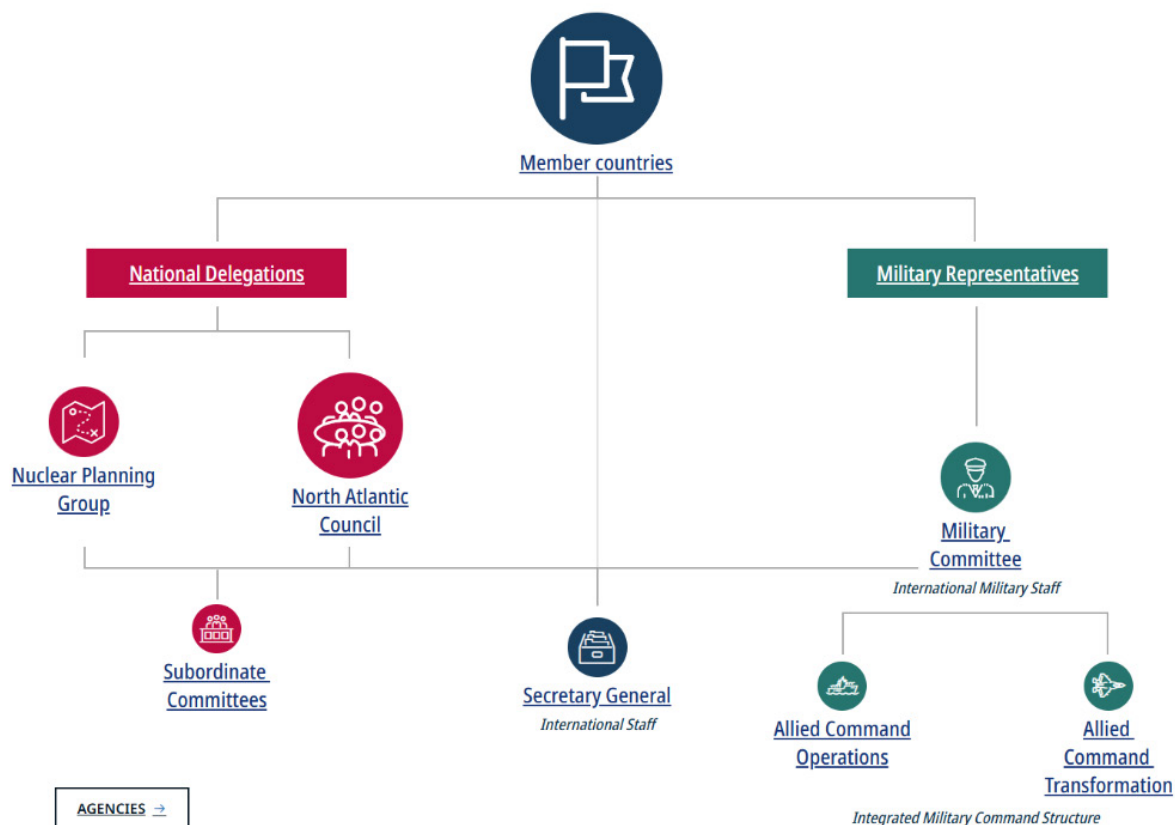
Collective defence

An armed attack against one or more members is considered an attack against them all. Each member commits to assist the member or members under attack with whatever action it deems necessary.

Article 5 is at the heart of NATO's collective defence.

03 — How NATO is organised

Working structures



NATO consists of 32 sovereign member countries, known as Allies. They come together to discuss political and security issues and make decisions by consensus.

03 — How NATO is organised

North Atlantic Council — NAC

NATO's principal political decision-making body. All member countries have a seat and participate in decisions concerning the Alliance's policies and security.

Military Committee — MC

NATO's senior military authority. It provides the link between political decision-making and NATO's integrated military structure. Each member country is represented by a senior military officer.

Allied Command Operations — ACO

Responsible for the planning and execution of NATO military operations. Based in Belgium and led by the Supreme Allied Commander Europe (SACEUR).

Allied Command Transformation — ACT

Leads NATO's military adaptation and development, ensuring that Allied forces maintain the capabilities needed to meet future challenges. Based in the United States and led by Supreme Allied Commander Transformation (SACT).

National Delegations

Each member country has a permanent delegation at NATO Headquarters in Brussels, representing its government in NATO consultations and decision-making.

Nuclear Planning Group — NPG

NATO's senior body for nuclear policy and nuclear deterrence matters.

Subordinate Committees

A network of committees brings together national representatives and experts to address political, military, technical and specialised issues.

03 — How NATO is organised

NATO's New Operational Domains

Cyberspace Operations Centre — CyOC

NATO recognised cyberspace as an operational domain in 2016. The CyOC coordinates NATO cyber operations, protects Alliance networks and strengthens collective cyber defence through monitoring, intelligence sharing and incident response

NATO Space Operations Centre — NSpOC

Space was recognised as an operational domain in 2019 alongside land, air, maritime and cyber. The NSpOC, located in Ramstein, Germany, coordinates NATO's space activities and supports operations through satellite communications, navigation and intelligence capabilities.

Both centres support NATO's ability to operate in increasingly complex environments where cyber attacks and threats to space assets can directly affect military operations and national security

Cyber and space capabilities are integrated into NATO's broader command structure and support *Allied Command Operations* (ACO) in planning and conducting military operations.

03 — How NATO is organised

Who Commands NATO Forces in the Field?

Joint Force Commander — JFC

Joint Force Commands are responsible for planning and conducting NATO operations. A Joint Force Commander coordinates forces across multiple domains, including land, air, maritime, and special operations, ensuring all elements work together to achieve the mission objectives.

Land Component Command – LANDCOM

LANDCOM serves as NATO's lead command for land operations. It provides expertise on land warfare, supports planning and training activities, and helps ensure that Allied land forces can operate effectively together. Key areas of responsibility include: Infantry operations, armoured forces and artillery.

Maritime Component Command – MARCOM

MARCOM is responsible for NATO's maritime operations. It coordinates Allied naval forces and helps protect critical sea lines of communication, ensuring freedom of navigation and maritime security. Key areas of responsibility include: Naval operations, maritime security and protection of shipping routes.

Air Component Command – AIRCOM

AIRCOM oversees NATO's air and air defence operations. It coordinates Allied air assets and ensures the Alliance can rapidly respond to threats in the air domain. Key areas of responsibility include: Air policing, air defence and fighter aircraft operations.

Special Operations Component Command – SOCC

SOCC coordinates NATO's special operations forces. These highly trained units conduct specialized missions that often require speed, precision, and discretion. Key areas of responsibility include: Special reconnaissance and special operations planning and coordination.

03 — How NATO is organised

Who Commands NATO Forces in the Field?

DIAGRAM OVER STRUKTUR

04 — NATO's Military Structure

NATO's military strength is based on the capabilities and forces provided by its member countries.

LAND DOMAIN — ARMY

Land forces operate on the ground and contribute to territorial defence, military operations and the protection of Allied nations.

SEA DOMAIN — NAVY

Naval forces operate at sea and contribute to maritime security, surveillance and the protection of sea lines and territories.

AIR DOMAIN — AIR FORCE

Air forces monitor and protect airspace and contribute to air defence, surveillance and military operations.

SPECIAL OPERATIONS DOMAIN – SOF

Special Operations Forces conduct specialized missions that require highly trained personnel and unique capabilities. Their tasks may include reconnaissance, and support to conventional military operations.

Together, land, maritime, air, and special operations forces form NATO's overall military capability, allowing the Alliance to respond effectively across multiple domains and operational environments.

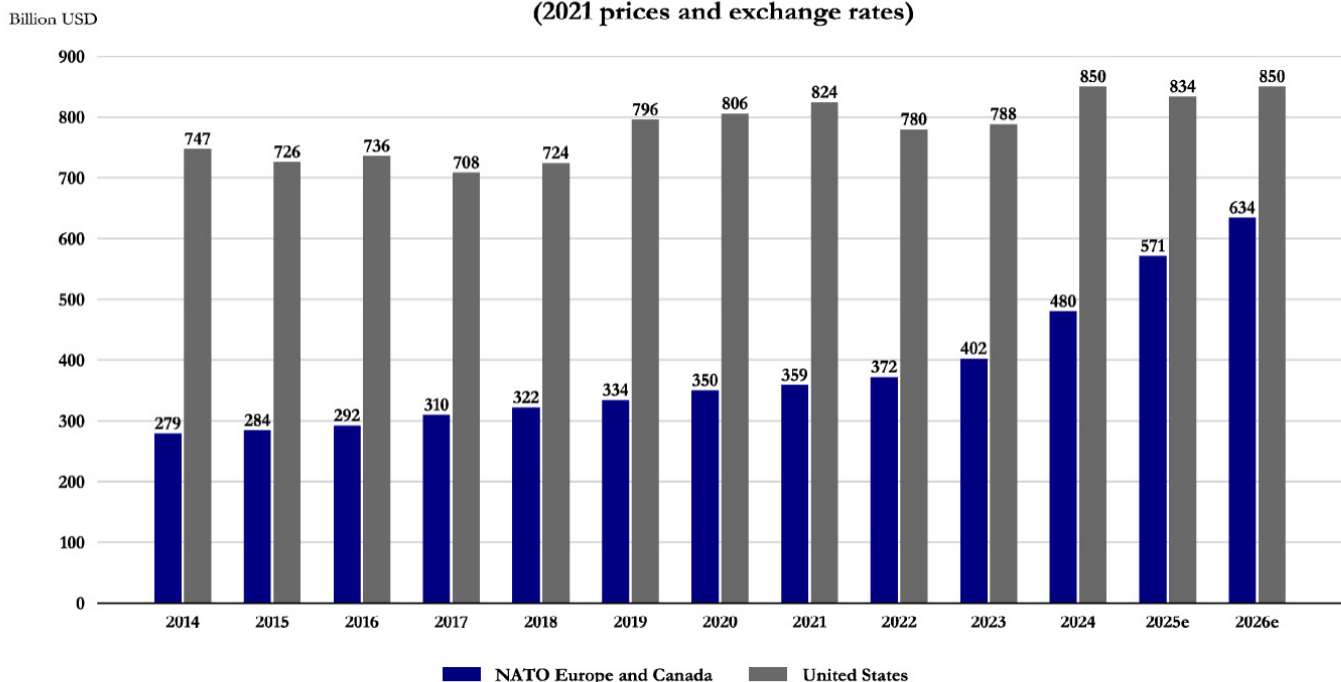
05 — Personal and market size of NATO.

NATO's defence spending

NATO's combined defence spending has increased significantly over the past decade. In 2025, total defence expenditure was estimated to reach approximately 1.4 trillion USD, compared to just over 1 trillion USD in 2014. NATO therefore represents one of the world's largest defence ecosystems.

The United States remains the largest contributor, but defence spending across European and Canadian Allies has increased significantly in recent years. This trend reflects a growing focus on strengthening NATO's collective defence and investing in modern military capabilities.

Graph 2 - Core Defence Expenditure - Billion \$
(2021 prices and exchange rates)



Notes: Data is based on Allies' submissions as at 03 July 2026. Based on 2021 prices and exchange rates. Figures for 2025 and 2026 are estimates. The NATO Europe and Canada aggregates from 2017 onwards include Montenegro, which became an Ally on 5 June 2017, from 2020 onwards include North Macedonia, which became an Ally on 27 March 2020, from 2023 onwards include Finland, which became an Ally on 4 April 2023, and from 2024 onwards include Sweden, which became an Ally on 7 March 2024.

05 — Personal and market size of NATO.

The Size of NATO

NATO currently consists of 32 member nations across Europe and North America with more than *1 billion* citizens represented. Together, these nations maintain approximately *3.65 millions* of military personnel across active duty, reserve, and national guard forces.

The Alliance's military strength is built on contributions from individual member states, enabling NATO to conduct operations across land, air, maritime, cyber, and special operations domains.

06 — Why supporting NATO is a worthy cause



07—NATO standardisation

And what does it mean for INVISIO



08—Key Organisations in the NATO Defence Ecosystem

And what does it mean for INVISIO

NATO Communications and Information Agency – NCIA

They are a team of over 3000 civilian and military experts working together to connect all corners of NATO and maintain its edge.

They enable NATO to fulfil its mission by providing digital solutions and *resilient communication and information services* that ensure seamless connectivity among Allied and partner nations.

They are a key partner in NATO's Digital Transformation, working hand in hand with industry to provide technical solutions and expertise, facilitating political consultations and enabling multi-domain operations.

As the organization is responsible for NATO's communication and information systems, NCIA plays a key role in areas closely aligned with INVISIO's solutions.

Through collaboration with industry, academia, and Allied partners, NCIA develops and integrates new technologies that strengthen NATO's operational capabilities and maintain the Alliance's technological edge.

08—Key Organisations in the NATO Defence Ecosystem

And what does it mean for INVISIO

NATO Support and Procurement Agency – NSPA

NSPA is NATO's primary organization for procurement, logistics, and support services. It provides cost-effective multinational solutions to NATO member nations and partners, helping them acquire, maintain, and sustain military capabilities.

Cooperation with industry is one of NSPA's major strengths that enables to develop state-of-the-art solutions and source the latest technologies for the Alliance. To successfully deliver these current and future capabilities for NATO and Partner Nations, and gain access to the latest developments, NSPA engages and works closely with industry at different stages of the acquisition and sustainment cycles.

As NATO's leading procurement and support agency, NSPA plays an important role in connecting defence companies with NATO nations. A strong understanding of NSPA helps INVISIO identify potential opportunities related to procurement, sustainment, and multinational defence projects

09 — What is NATO standardization

And why is it important for INVISIO

Standardization Agreements – STANAG

STANAG helps ensure that equipment, systems, procedures, and technologies used by NATO member nations are compatible and interoperable. This is important for INVISIO, as products intended for NATO users should be developed with relevant STANAG requirements in mind to ensure they can operate effectively alongside Allied systems.

The Multinational Interoperability Council – MIC

MIC is an international forum that brings together military experts from participating nations to improve interoperability across allied forces. MIC helps identify and address multinational interoperability challenges related to communications, information sharing, command and control, and joint operations. Although it is not a procurement organisation, its work influences the standards, requirements, and operational needs that defence companies must consider when developing products for NATO and Allied forces.

10— NATO's Decision-Making

32 Allies

NATO brings together 32 sovereign nations.

Consensus

NATO decisions represent the collective will of all member countries. Decisions are made by consensus rather than majority vote.

Political & Military

NATO's political and military structures work closely together to translate political decisions into military capabilities and action.

Cooperation

NATO works with partner countries and international organisations to strengthen security and address shared challenges.

*NATO
One Alliance.
32 Allies.
Collective Defence.*